
EMart – Digital Transformation Journey by Manisha Kriplani

1. Overview of Digital Transformation

EMart transitioned from a traditional retail model to an omnichannel digital ecosystem over the past decade. How the EMart is now operating on multiple channels? Initially the firm was just a retail business provider and when the firm was made digital meaning we setup a website and an app featuring all our products and making buying and selling very convenient from just a few clicks sitting at home, anywhere and delivering products in 10 mins at the addressed doorstep. Think about Instamart and Bigbasket where the shop comes to its customers.

- **Timeline & Milestones:**
 - **Phase 1: E-commerce launch and ERP modernization-** where the firm was made digital to its customers bringing the everyday shop home directly instead of manually visiting the stores. Also managing the inventory, business model, employees, billing orders are also upgraded to smoothen the process and align it better.
 - **Phase 2: Omnichannel integration of online + in-store sync-** where the firm integrated offline store with digital platform for easy customer experience to generate more profits.
 - **Phase 3: AI-driven personalization & data platforms-** to create better experience for its customers and automate internal processes for better and enhanced decision making. When any platform goes digital it streamlines data quality, accessibility and trust among its employees and customers.
- **Strategic Objectives:** Enhance customer experience, improve operational efficiency, and enable data-driven decision-making. All of which are necessary for the firm to perform and sustain in the long run which creates a positive customer experience and eventually the firm becomes strategically sound and scalable in future.
- **Key Innovations:** Mobile apps, real-time inventory visibility, and personalized recommendation engines- all these key features the firm provides results in better customer experience. The more the app is easy to use, scroll the products/ inventory available, all time availability of products enhances user experience which increases the user turn around index and ratio.

2. Challenges and Opportunities

- **Challenges:** Legacy systems, resistance to change, fragmented customer data, and high implementation costs. All these challenges led EMart to go digital making an inline move with the ever changing world.

- **Opportunities:** Growing digital adoption, data monetization, improved supply chain visibility, and enhanced customer engagement. In today's world if any firm is not digital it will hardly survive the market competition and eventually fall. It is today very necessary for new businesses to come up only digital at the very start to eventually not just survive but create an impact with its technology, talent, ease of use, customer experience and data modernization and trust and data privacy. All of these when combined generates numerous opportunities both internally and externally.
- **Insight:** External competition and evolving customer expectations accelerated transformation urgency. This insight to become better and improvise is very important to lead the market and create an impact.

3. Strategies to Align the Organization

- **Restructuring:** Shift to cross-functional digital teams. Restructuring is important for the process to function, for the employees to adapt to new technologies, for the new horizons to come into picture, looking at the business model from a different perspective to create a business mode perhaps which is robust, fault tolerant and which can not just survive the market but lead it.
- **Talent Acquisition:** Hiring data scientists, digital marketers, and cloud engineers. The firm hired data scientist to build and execute API logic, digital marketers to publish and come up with better marketing strategies to expand business and reach even the remote users and customers.
- **Technology Adoption:** Cloud platforms like Snowflake to process and compute huge volumes of data and support AI driven analytics and decision making, Generative AI- to recommend products to users based on ML algorithms and predictive analysis also copilot inside the app to better guide the customers and resolve any customer query, Real time data and microservices- like Kafka to easily maintain 1000+ messages for instant orders, inventory and payments.
- **Alignment:** All initiatives tied to a unified digital-first business strategy. The goal is online growth- the firm invests in apps to improve delivery and use data, hire tech people. This makes the firm digital first system where goal and vision is crystal clear.

4. Organizational Structure, Culture & Change Management

- **Structure:** Agile, product-based teams replacing siloed departments. Agility comes in hand with digitization. When EMart is structured to be adaptable it promises new growth and sweeter experiences to help expand the business. Legacy systems were replaced with restructured AI ecosystem.
- **Culture:** Innovation-driven, data-centric mindset encouraged. EMart created a culture shift by adapting agile first, innovation at its core and streamlined logic to handle, process and compute huge volumes of customer data at ease.
- **Change Management:**

- Leadership-driven transformation vision- a leadership driven vision is also essential for a firm to revolutionize its business. For example. today the firm is delivering customers orders in 10min, tomorrow it will be-
 - Auto deliver essentials- the app will just deliver the order without customers having to use the app and place any order like milk, diapers etc.
 - Voice and AI shopping- where customers will just say order and AI handles everything – selection, payment, delivery like a smart assistant.
 - Smart home integrations- where our fridge will automatically order the ran out essentials.
 - Sustainable and optimized delivery- where AI will use EV, drones for faster and greener delivery.
- **Continuous employee upskilling programs**- this makes sure the firm is always using the latest technology and that the technology the firm has decided to use is always scalable. Trainings are very important for the employees to make better logical decisions.
- **Incentives for digital adoption**- sometimes people need a push to stop using old methodologies and start a change. This push could be a 50/- off when ordered from website/ app for customers. For employees it could be rewards, bonuses, or recognition when they use new digital systems instead of old processes.
- **Outcome:** Reduced resistance and improved collaboration across teams. When organizational structure is such a star the future of a legacy retail store could and would perhaps change and become an example for other firms to go digital.

5. Customer Understanding

- **Data-Driven Insights:** Analysis of purchase behavior, browsing patterns, and feedback. The business logic should be able to analyze customer purchase pattern using predictive analysis and ML algorithms. For processing and computation the firm should use powerful technologies like Snowflake running on top of cloud to build further analytics and drive business decisions.
- **Customer Personas:**
 - *Digital Savvy Shopper:* Prefers mobile-first, personalized experience. The firm very first persona is of a digital savvy shopper where the shopper is extremely happy to use the app and order essentials which are delivered within minutes.
 - *Value Seeker:* Looks for discounts and deals. This is the second persona where a shopper is a value seeker who looks for discounts and fair deals. This person could shift from EMart to any other similar app like Instamart/ BB/ Amazon for better discounts. To keep such personas stick to EMart is to give them new offers like-
 - **Personalized deals**- Discounts based on their past purchases which feels exclusive like buy 1 get 1 free
 - **Loyalty rewards**- Points/cashback for all the repeat orders.

- **Price lock and best price guarantee-** Assures them they're getting the lowest price
 - **Smart bundles-** Frequently bought together at a cheaper combined price
 - **Subscription savings-** Monthly plans for essentials at lower cost
- *Omnichannel Buyer:* Switches between online and offline seamlessly. The last persona is that of an omnichannel buyer where the buyer sometimes visits the store and does the purchase and sometimes orders through the app.
- **Pain Points Identified:** Lack of personalization, inconsistent experiences, and delayed deliveries. Sometimes there is internet lag, sometimes the app is not updated, sometimes the website is having down time maintenance, all these could make customers feel the app is not smart and smooth and fast enough.

6. Customer Journey Mapping & Optimization

- **Stages Covered:** the app has a lifecycle where it covers and goes through following stages-
 - Awareness- where the customers come to know about EMart at the very first place. Knock knock, now EMart is delivering essentials at home.
 - Consideration- where customers checks prices, compare it with other similar apps, reads reviews. Then finally consider it.
 - Purchase- where customers decides and places the order and finally makes a purchase.
 - Delivery- the product is delivered to the customer.
 - Post-sale- after buying the customer return and come back to order further essentials. There is a feedback page where customers can tells us what went well and what could be improved. They show the firm their love by supporting us and making future purchases.
- **Key Pain Points:**
 - Discovery: Irrelevant recommendations- sometimes due to technical glitches the app could show the user irrelevant data. The reason for this could be the app is not updated. Or the user's internet is at a lag.
 - Purchase: Complex checkout- sometimes when the processes are too new to customers they may feel the system too complex.
 - Delivery: Lack of real-time tracking- again due to lag in internet this might come up or the app is having an update issue.
- **Optimizations Implemented:**
 - AI-based recommendations- for a smoother customer experience and 100% come back index AI based recommendations help a lot to achieve this.
 - One-click checkout- again technology today is just a click away and tomorrow it could be a voice signalling and triggering the delivery at home and many more.

- Real-time order tracking and proactive notifications- again to smoothen the make customer experience so better that they are knowing what is internally happening with their order at each step. This surely delights the customer further and increases come back ratio and conversion rate too.
- **Outcome:** Improved customer satisfaction, retention, and conversion rates. When customers are happier, come back more often, and more visitors turn into helps EMart to build a successful digital first online business.